■ THE DAILY GOODS STORY SCOUT - Wednesday, September 23, 2026

TODAY'S RUNDOWN SLOTS

THE LIST (5 stories)

■ *Raiders' Kirk Cousins reveals shocking love interest*

The Angle: *The Raiders are rolling at 2-0 for the first time since 2021, and a loose, winning locker room means players start opening up about stuff way outside football - like Kirk Cousins' old celebrity crush. It's the kind of goofy, human-interest nugget that makes a 15-year NFL vet feel relatable.*

- **Kirk Cousins** and the **Raiders** are off to a **2-0 start** - their best since **2021**
- **Cousins** is a **15-year NFL veteran**, now getting the lighter, off-field questions thanks to the winning streak
- Reporters pressed him on a **childhood crush**, and he actually answered

The Guess-Who Game

- Before you read the reveal - who do you think Kirk Cousins' childhood crush was?

nypost.com (Tier 1) | Score: 86/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 29 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://nypost.com/2026/09/23/sports/kirk-cousins-reveals-meagan-good-as-celebrity-crush/

■ *Norway's EV transition is nearing completion, with electric cars making up a record 98.7% of new passenger car registrations in August. EVs now account for 97.8% of new cars sold in 2026 so far, up from 94.5% during the same period last year.*

The Angle: *Nearly every new car sold in Norway last month was electric — this is what the endgame of the EV transition actually looks like, and it's a real preview of where North America's own EV debate could be headed.*

- **98.7%** of new passenger car registrations in Norway last month were **electric**
- EVs make up **97.8%** of all new car sales in Norway so far in **2026**
- That's up from **94.5%** during the same stretch last year — gas cars are basically rounding error now
- Norway didn't ban gas cars outright — this is the market just tipping almost all the way over

The Debate Starter

- Could North America ever realistically hit numbers like that, or are we just too big and too spread out for it to work the same way?

Reddit r/upliftingnews (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://insideevs.com/news/806799/norway-ev-sales-98-percent/

■ *In drought hit France, corn grown beneath 5,500 rotating solar panels produced 19.6% more plant matter than open field corn, with plants averaging 79 inches versus 63 inches. The elevated panels helped protect the crop from the season's extreme heat and drought.*

The Angle: *It sounds backwards — shade should hurt a crop, not help it — but as droughts get worse, this 'grow food under solar panels' trick might be the future of farming, and it actually worked better than the old-school method.*

- Corn grown under **5,500 rotating solar panels** produced **19.6% more plant matter** than corn in an open field.
- Shaded corn plants averaged **79 inches tall**, compared to just **63 inches** for unprotected corn.
- The panels tilt to protect crops from extreme heat and drought — this was tested during a drought-hit growing season in **France**.

- It's essentially two harvests off the same acre: **solar power** and **food**, grown together on purpose.

The Debate Starter

- Would you trust 'solar farm corn' on your dinner plate, or does this feel like sci-fi science that's too good to be true?

Reddit r/upliftingnews (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://www.autonocion.com/us/5500-panels-corn-outgrew-open-rows/

■ *Trump says Canada is 'destroying itself' with immigration. Ministers say that's bogus*

The Angle: *Trump is trashing Canada's immigration system on the world stage, and Canadian ministers are calling him flat-out wrong — a cross-border war of words that touches politics, national pride, and the always-hot immigration debate.*

- **Donald Trump** claimed Canada is **"destroying itself"** with its immigration policy
- Trump alleged the country let in **"millions"** of people without proper security checks
- Federal ministers pushed back hard, calling the comments **"ill-informed"** and **"grossly inaccurate"**

The Debate Starter

- Is Trump calling out a real problem or just stirring the pot with Canada again?

www.cbc.ca (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://www.cbc.ca/news/politics/trump-canada-immigration-unemployment-9.7355556?cmp=rss

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■ *FBI employee data allegedly hacked by ShinyHunters contains sensitive info about intelligence roles*

The Angle: *A hacking group called ShinyHunters allegedly stole internal FBI personnel data revealing exactly who's working which spy cases - from Chinese and Russian intelligence to cartel investigations. If real, this isn't just a data breach, it's a potential roadmap for foreign adversaries.*

- Hacking group **ShinyHunters** allegedly breached FBI employee data, according to **Reuters**
- The stolen data reportedly includes granular job assignment details for **"scores" of bureau officials**
- Sensitive assignments allegedly exposed include work against **Chinese spies**, **Russian intelligence**, and **drug cartels**
- Reuters is the outlet that broke and verified the findings on the alleged breach

The Debate Starter

- If a hack like this is real, does it make you trust government data security less - or is this just the cost of living in 2026?

www.cbc.ca (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://www.cbc.ca/news/world/shinyhunters-fbi-hack-9.7355635?cmp=rss

Backup options:

■■ *Trump says Canada 'destroying itself' with high immigration levels, data show numbers going down*

The Angle: *Trump's taking shots at Canada's immigration policy again, except the actual data says intake is dropping, not spiking — a classic 'the numbers don't back the claim' story that's tailor-made for a debate segment on both sides of the border.*

- **Donald Trump** claims Canada is **'destroying itself'** with high immigration levels
- Data cited in the report shows Canada's immigration numbers are actually **going down**, not up
- Story comes via **CTV News**, framing a direct contradiction between the claim and the stats

The Debate Starter

- Is this just Trump being Trump on Canada, or does it touch a nerve because immigration numbers ARE a real political fight up here too?

CTV News (via Google News) (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://news.google.com/rss/articles/CBMivAFBVV95cUxQV0VpTXgzZjk3djJUX0FaSVh1UkFua1B3TmZMbDQxZkV4ZXJXSE45b3lqUUQzZnNFMVQ2VG44WXNCZHo2Yk5VTTdrLTRwbktHaHo0Vng2b1FHdXdaLU40SjVhbHoxcWN5SjcyWUZldHZ5ZExzNTJHVURDNVZlS01mS18yYkphQTZaUE9OeTVlMVcyT0lGM185aVN4akVMYklaTEJ5VnpsSk0tYlJvbmI4azZEWk5ySFl4aS1oYg?oc=5

■ *Trump has a 'sledgehammer' way to slash diesel prices. But it could boomerang back on the U.S.*

The Angle: *Diesel prices hit truckers, shippers, and eventually your grocery bill — so a president floating a blunt-force fix to bring costs down is national pocketbook news, especially with a built-in "this could backfire" twist that makes for an easy debate.*

- Trump is reportedly eyeing a **"sledgehammer"** approach to force diesel prices lower.
- The move could **boomerang** back and end up hurting the U.S. instead of helping it, per the report.
- Diesel costs ripple through **trucking, shipping, and food prices** — so this isn't just a gas-pump story.

The Debate Starter

- Would you take a quick win at the pump if it risked a bigger economic hit down the road?

CTV News (via Google News) (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://news.google.com/rss/articles/CBMiygFBVV95cUxQaHNleG5BcFozb3I4akdNY0RrRkViOE90TjhBdGJ2aUZDckdxN2QtV3JyOXlkLVl1eGJyLXNQTUNMRV9nX3IwNHlzV3pWaHh6T0dWZFM2bXZBYm96cFBaNGxUc3c4WW4tRWxxWUlJZ1JUckNUdTd3aXpwTGpYVzRzOUtoMGlBdndKMXFMM05tUVJSNzE1ejdNWHFnRUNxVlh4RU05aWlrLVVOVUJ3MmxKbmNLUTRvOVo0aUFxTmlLSERveUhReDJJNGlR?oc=5

CANADIAN NEWS (3 stories)

■ *Carney tells NYT he studied risk of U.S.-led military action in Canada*

The Angle: *The Canadian PM just told the New York Times his government actually studied the risk of the U.S. military moving on Canada - a stunning admission about how far Trump-era tension has pushed the relationship, even with Carney downplaying it as covering an 'extreme tail risk.'*

- **Mark Carney** told the **New York Times** he studied the possibility of **U.S.-led military action** against Canada.
- He wouldn't detail what that analysis actually involved.
- Carney framed it as basic due diligence, calling it preparation for an **'extreme tail risk'**.
- He argued it would be **irresponsible** not to have looked into it.

The Debate Starter

- Is this smart contingency planning from a PM doing his job, or a sign the Canada-U.S. relationship is in scarier shape than anyone's admitting?

www.cbc.ca (Tier 1) | Score: 82/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 25 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://www.cbc.ca/news/canada/carney-nyt-interview-9.7356284?cmp=rss

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■ *Canada's boycott forces the sale of a California winery*

The Angle: *Cross-border consumer boycotts have been simmering all year, but this one didn't just hurt sales - it reportedly forced an actual sale of the winery, which is a whole new level of "put your money where your mouth is."*

The Debate Starter

- Does a boycott actually work, or is this a one-off - call in and tell us if you've ditched a brand over where it's from.

Reddit r/canada (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://www.latimes.com/business/story/2026-09-23/canadas-boycott-forces-sale-of-california-winery

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■■ *Canada pledges $100M for Palestine at United Nations General Assembly*

The Angle: *A nine-figure pledge at the UN puts Canada squarely in the middle of the global debate over the Israel-Gaza conflict and foreign aid spending - the kind of move that splits opinion fast.*

- **Canada** pledged **$100 million** for Palestine at the **United Nations General Assembly**
- The announcement comes as world leaders gather in New York for the annual UN session, with the Israel-Gaza conflict dominating the agenda
- It reignites the ongoing debate over how much Canada should be spending abroad versus at home

The Debate Starter

- Is $100 million the right move for Canada right now - or should that money stay home?

Reddit r/canada (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://www.cbc.ca/news/politics/carney-gaza-aid-israel-west-bank-9.7354263

Backup options:

■ *Southwestern Mexico braces for arrival of 'extremely dangerous' Hurricane Polo*

The Angle: *It's officially a major hurricane now, and forecasters are calling it 'extremely dangerous' - plus there's a second storm setting up to hammer Hawaii, so this is shaping up to be a rough week for anyone with a beach vacation booked.*

- **Hurricane Polo** has strengthened into a **major** Pacific hurricane
- Southwestern **Mexico** is bracing for heavy rains and mudslides starting **Wednesday**
- Forecasters are describing Polo as **"extremely dangerous"**
- A separate storm system is tracking toward **Hawaii**, with forecasters warning of possible **"catastrophic flooding"** later in the week

The Travel Alert

- Anyone got a trip to Mexico or Hawaii booked this week? This might be the storm that wrecks those plans.

www.cbc.ca (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://www.cbc.ca/news/world/nhc-polo-mexico-california-9.7354826?cmp=rss

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■ *PM Carney prepared for ‘risk’ that Trump might order U.S.-led military invasion of Canada: report*

The Angle: *This is the kind of story that sounds like satire until you realize it's a real report about a sitting PM's government preparing contingency plans for the unthinkable — a U.S. military move against Canada.*

- **PM Mark Carney** is reportedly being briefed on the **'risk'** that **Trump** could order a **U.S.-led military invasion of Canada**
- The claim comes from a new report, not from Carney or the PMO directly
- No specific trigger, timeline, or military details are included in what's been reported so far

The Debate Starter

- Wildest headline of the week or a real geopolitical red flag — where do you land?

CTV News (via Google News) (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://news.google.com/rss/articles/CBMimwFBVV95cUxOVWpBZk5NZW5jekxjMTFmM3U5eXhoRUJpMEY1QlhyQ3BCYThER2lDbUExY0g1TjI4Rk1FN29hcVc0VTlFUDRtRkZPVXo4UkdmbzJVYmdfT1VtbzhiNno2TlRDWVhGaUQxZkJGQ3lNZGRLaER4THk1aGpldmVMSHk2RlQ4RTlqeDNyNzJtSmkycnNmSlVTMmJmUlF3bw?oc=5

■ *Canadian author accused of using AI for prize-winning novel, publishers defend writer*

The Angle: *A Canadian author is under fire for allegedly using AI to help pen their prize-winning book, and their publisher is now publicly backing them up — it's the literary world colliding head-on with the AI authenticity debate everyone's already arguing about.*

- A **Canadian author** is being accused of using **AI** in the writing of their **prize-winning novel**

- The author's **publishers** have come out publicly to **defend the writer** against the claims
- No word yet on which AI tool is allegedly involved or how the accusation surfaced

The Debate Starter

- If AI helped polish a prize-winning book, does the award still count — or is that cheating?

CTV News (via Google News) (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://news.google.com/rss/articles/CBMiygFBVV95cUxPWm9maWxJb1Y5bkQyMG84QTF6TlVhZzFFX0NpMHFtTUpIN0ZaWEZobXlfNmpvTV84WUgtNDJUR1ZPbnNHa1pkWUVGUHhXSy1jSlVESnN6cEVQMmJSemlQcmZRMThuVVcxZW5HNmpkYlZyNDAwS0xhWDhXMWxybWFFRnRSNzMzemd0WHFTRTVtVHhxYUU0THIwM0ZTeUpReXlsSnNRSnJfc2Eyckt0UlFsRHZCYm5DNjg2VHZISW9GejRnYlpiTE9kaWJ3?oc=5

ENTERTAINMENT (4 stories)

■ *Journalist explains how viral Mike Macdonald-Sean Payton feud video came to be: 'Error in my judgement'*

The Angle: *Everyone's seen the viral clip of Seahawks coach Mike Macdonald and Broncos coach Sean Payton going at it - now the journalist who caught it is admitting there's more to the story of how it got out.*

- The journalist behind the viral **Mike Macdonald**-**Sean Payton** clip is speaking out about how it came together
- He calls it an **'error in my judgement'** - his own words
- The clip has been ricocheting around NFL circles since it dropped

The Debate Starter

- Is this a real apology or just damage control now that the clip's already viral?

nypost.com (Tier 1) | Score: 86/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 29 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://nypost.com/2026/09/23/sports/how-viral-mike-macdonald-sean-payton-feud-video-came-to-be/

■ *'Incredibles' director Brad Bird talks new Netflix movie 'Ray Gunn,' and why it was 30 years in the making*

The Angle: *Brad Bird — the guy behind The Incredibles, Ratatouille, and The Iron Giant — is dropping a Netflix movie he's been trying to make for three decades, which is exactly the kind of 'wait, why did it take THAT long' story that gets a conversation going.*

- **Brad Bird**, Oscar-winning director of **The Incredibles**, **Ratatouille**, and **The Iron Giant**, has a new Netflix film called **Ray Gunn**
- The project has reportedly been **over 30 years** in the making
- **Netflix** held a top-secret press event around the film's reveal

The Debate Starter

- What's a passion project you'd wait 30 years to finally pull off?

pagesix.com (Tier 2) | Score: 86/90 (45 fit + 8 source + 33 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://pagesix.com/2026/09/23/hollywood/incredibles-director-brad-bird-talks-new-netflix-movie-ray-gunn-and-why-it-was-30-years-in-the-making/

■ *Ryan Murphy Says He 'Just Finished the Script' for a 'Glee' Reboot and Has Spoken to the Original Cast: 'They All Were Very Enthusiastic'*

The Angle: *Glee was a straight-up cultural phenomenon a decade ago, so any reboot talk is instant nostalgia bait — and now the creator himself is confirming it's real, not just fan rumor.*

- **Ryan Murphy** told **Entertainment Tonight** on Wednesday: "I just finished the script an hour ago."
- Murphy says co-creator **Brad Falchuk** is involved in the reboot plans.
- Murphy has already reached out to the **original cast**, saying **"they all were very enthusiastic."**

The Nostalgia Trigger

- Callers — are you actually watching a Glee reboot, or is this one better left as a memory?

ON-AIR BIT BREAKDOWN

- **Step 1: Dream Cast Callout** - 2-3 min phone/social bit -> Ask listeners which original Glee cast members they'd want back for the reboot, and who they'd cut
- **Step 2: Host Pick: Best Glee Cover** - Quick back-and-forth -> Each host names their favorite Glee musical number/cover and makes the case for it on air

variety.com (Tier 2) | Score: 82/90 (45 fit + 8 source + 29 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://variety.com/2026/tv/news/ryan-murphy-glee-reboot-script-1236873863/

■ *'No Famous Person Has Stood Beside Them': Rosie O'Donnell Plans Epstein Series After 'Jimmy Kimmel Live!' Rejection*

The Angle: *Rosie O'Donnell says she pitched an Epstein docuseries and got turned down by 'Jimmy Kimmel Live!' — a juicy behind-the-scenes spat that doubles as a jab at how gun-shy late night is on the topic.*

- **Rosie O'Donnell** says she's moving forward with a series about **Jeffrey Epstein**
- She claims the project was rejected by **'Jimmy Kimmel Live!'**
- Her line: **'No famous person has stood beside them'** — pointing at survivors getting overlooked
- Frames it as a story that's been slow-walked by mainstream media/entertainment gatekeepers

The Debate Starter

- Is Hollywood actually avoiding the Epstein story, or is Rosie just stirring the pot?

Reddit r/entertainment (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://www.fashiontimes.co.uk/rosie-odonnell-epstein-survivor-interviews-1764442

Backup options:

■ *Robert Pattinson Says ‘The Batman 2’ Is ‘So Ambitious’ and a ‘Different Take’ on the Franchise: ‘It’s a Real Left Turn From the First’*

The Angle: *Fans have been dying for any scrap of intel on the Batman sequel, and Pattinson himself is now teasing it won't just be more of the same — that's the kind of comment that gets comment sections arguing instantly.*

- **Robert Pattinson** calls **'The Batman 2'** "**so ambitious**"
- He describes it as a "**different take**" on the franchise
- His exact words: "**It's a real left turn from the first**"

The Debate Starter

- Do you want a sequel that plays it safe, or are you here for Pattinson's promised 'left turn'?

Reddit r/entertainment (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://variety.com/2026/film/news/robert-pattinson-batman-2-different-take-1236872971/

■ *Marcus Semien sticks it to his former team with go-ahead homer as Mets beat Rangers*

The Angle: *A former Blue Jay/A's fan-favorite goes deep against the club that let him walk, and the crowd let him hear about it — classic sports revenge-game drama, even if the ending twists.*

- **Marcus Semien** hit a go-ahead homer against his **former team**
- Fans **booed** him in the **eighth inning**
- The **Mets** ended up beating the **Rangers**

The Debate Starter

- Is booing a guy for doing his job against his old team classy fandom or just bitter?

nypost.com (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://nypost.com/2026/09/23/sports/marcus-semien-sticks-it-to-his-former-team-with-go-ahead-homer-as-mets-drub-rangers/

■ *Matthew McConaughey and Woody Harrelson Explain Their ‘Brothers’ TV Idea — and What Happened at the Emmys - hollywoodreporter.com*

The Angle: *These two have been inseparable for 30 years, they genuinely believe they might be half-brothers, and they just teased the whole theory in a viral Emmys moment that's now becoming an actual Apple TV comedy.*

- **Matthew McConaughey** and **Woody Harrelson** have been best friends for **three decades**
- The duo believe they may actually be **half-brothers**
- Their **2026 Emmys** bit played off the theory and teased their new **Apple TV comedy** based on it
- **Woody Harrelson** won an Emmy back in **1989** for **Cheers**

The Debate Starter

- Callers: would you want to find out a lifelong best friend is secretly your brother, or is some mystery better left alone?

Hollywood Reporter (via NewsAPI) (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: http://www.hollywoodreporter.com/tv/tv-features/woody-harrelson-matthew-mcconaughey-emmys-brothers-show-1236707655/

■ *Isabel Sandoval, Tricia Tuttle, ‘Elephants in the Fog’ Producer Anup Poudel Join QueerFrames Mentor Lineup as Lab Unveils New Cohort, Southeast Asia Expansion (EXCLUSIVE)*

The Angle: *Representation in Hollywood keeps expanding behind the camera, and this lab is quietly building the next wave of queer storytellers across a whole new region.*

- **QueerFrames Screenwriting Lab** is expanding into **Southeast Asia** for its 4th annual edition.
- New cohort pulls storytellers from **India, the Philippines, Vietnam, Singapore, Indonesia** and the diaspora.
- The **2026 cohort** features **8 fiction feature projects**, all centering queer stories.
- New mentors joining include **Isabel Sandoval**, **Tricia Tuttle**, and **'Elephants in the Fog' producer Anup Poudel**.

The Industry Angle

- Behind-the-scenes labs like this rarely make headlines, but they're where the next indie breakout director usually gets discovered first.

variety.com (Tier 2) | Score: 74/90 (45 fit + 8 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://variety.com/2026/film/news/queerframes-lab-expands-southeast-asia-fourth-cohort-2-1236871948/

TRENDING TODAY

■ *‘Dancing with the Stars’ Recap: 1 Star Gets Sent Home on Viral Hits Night After Breaking Down in Tears at Practice - People.com*

The Angle: *Week 2 of 'Dancing with the Stars' just got emotional and dramatic - a contestant broke down crying at practice before getting sent home on Viral Hits Night, and host Alfonso Ribeiro revealed voting numbers blew past the previous week's totals.*

- **Season 35**, Week 2 was themed **'Viral Hits Night'** with **14 contestants** competing
- Host **Alfonso Ribeiro** revealed voting had already **surpassed the total votes** from either previous night - halfway through the show
- One star broke down in **tears at practice** before getting eliminated on air
- Contestants are competing for the **Len Goodman Mirrorball** trophy

The Debate Starter

- Was this elimination the right call, or did America get it wrong?

PEOPLE (via NewsAPI) (Tier 1) | Score: 86/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 29 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://people.com/dancing-with-the-stars-reacap-viral-hits-night-who-gets-sent-home-12135518

Backup options:

■ *Is it unprofessional to bring iced coffee to a job interview? Gen Z is being dragged for it*

The Angle: *It's a classic generational flashpoint dressed up as a coffee cup - a viral debate over whether showing up caffeinated reads as chill confidence or a red flag, and it's splitting the internet right down age lines.*

- The debate has gone **viral**, splitting reactions largely along generational lines.
- Critics argue walking into an interview holding an **iced coffee** signals an unserious, too-casual attitude.
- Defenders push back, saying staying **caffeinated** has nothing to do with how qualified or professional someone is.
- It's become a broader stand-in for the bigger fight over **Gen Z workplace norms** vs. old-school interview etiquette.

The Debate Starter

- Would you show up to a job interview with an iced coffee in hand - harmless habit or instant red flag?

www.cbc.ca (Tier 1) | Score: 82/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 25 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://www.cbc.ca/news/canada/ice-coffee-job-interviews-gen-z-9.7353458?cmp=rss

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■ *California now requires influencers to disclose paid political ads, with fines of up to $5,000 for each violation, bringing greater transparency to sponsored political content on social media and giving voters clearer information about who is paying for it.*

The Angle: *If you're an influencer in California and someone pays you to push a political message, you now have to say so — or risk a hefty fine. It's a real test case for how the law starts catching up to social media's role in elections.*

- **California** now legally requires influencers to disclose **paid political advertisements**
- Violators face fines of up to **$5,000 per incident**
- The goal: giving voters clearer info on **who's actually paying** for the political content in their feed

The Debate Starter

- Should every state make influencers disclose political payments, or is this government overreach into social media?

Reddit r/upliftingnews (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://techcrunch.com/2026/09/20/new-california-law-will-penalize-influencers-dont-disclose-political-ads/

LIFESTYLE CHAT

■ *Wow feminism...*

The Angle: *A viral eye-roll tweet aimed at feminism is racking up reactions online, and it's the kind of one-liner that instantly splits a comment section - perfect fuel for a quick lifestyle debate.*

The Debate Starter

- Is this fair criticism or just internet snark dressed up as a take?

X/Twitter @WomenBeingAwful (Tier 1) | Score: 80/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 23 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://x.com/WomenBeingAwful/status/2102782328686690442

Backup options:

■ *A new evolutionary theory suggests that consciousness did not simply emerge from high intelligence, but rather evolved as a distinct adaptation to help fragile organisms coordinate competing survival needs and manage self-maintenance under threat.*

The Angle: *A new theory says consciousness didn't just show up once we got smart enough — it evolved specifically to help fragile bodies juggle competing survival needs, like a built-in referee for hunger vs. fear vs. fatigue. It's a fun 'wait, what am I actually thinking with' rabbit hole for a slow-news lifestyle segment.*

- The theory flips the usual assumption that **consciousness emerged from high intelligence**
- Instead, it frames consciousness as a **distinct evolutionary adaptation**, not a byproduct of brainpower
- Purpose: helping **fragile organisms coordinate competing survival needs**
- Also tied to **self-maintenance under threat** — basically triage mode for the body

The Debate Starter

- Ask listeners: do you think your 'gut feeling' is really just your brain running survival triage — and when's the last time it overruled your logic?

Reddit r/science (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://www.psypost.org/consciousness-may-have-evolved-to-solve-a-problem-that-pure-intelligence-couldnt-handle-fascinating-new-theory-suggests/

■ *The assumption that men's interest in sex is purely physical and always switched on is a common stereotype, but recent evidence indicates that men's sexual desire is actually quite complex. When men felt happy and equal in their partnerships, their interest in solitary sexual activities decreased.*

The Angle: *It flips the tired stereotype that guys are just wired to always want sex — new research suggests happiness and equality in a relationship actually change what men want, which is a fun myth-buster for a couples conversation.*

- New research challenges the stereotype that **men's sexual desire** is purely physical and **always "on."**
- The study found men's interest in **solitary sexual activity** actually **decreased** when they felt **happy and equal** in their relationships.
- The takeaway: **emotional connection**, not just biology, seems to drive male desire.

The Debate Starter

- Does this match what you've seen in your own relationship — happier couples, less solo time?

Reddit r/science (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL:
https://www.psypost.org/new-study-highlights-key-differences-in-how-relationship-dynamics-relate-to-sexual-desire-in-men-and-women/

CLOSER: THE KICKER/GOODBYES

■ *Dunkin' customer accidentally orders 6,000 donuts instead of 60. Once the mistake was realized, the store decided to turn the situation into a wholesome community gesture.*

The Angle: *A classic "oops" moment everyone can relate to — a customer meant to order 60 donuts, typo'd it into 6,000 — but instead of a refund nightmare, the store turned it into a feel-good giveaway for the whole community.*

- A **Dunkin'** customer accidentally ordered **6,000 donuts** instead of **60**
- Rather than scrap the order, the store leaned into the mistake
- Employees turned the glut into a **wholesome community giveaway**

The Phone-In Trigger

- If 6,000 donuts landed on your doorstep by mistake tomorrow, what's the first thing you'd do with them?

Reddit r/upliftingnews (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://www.operationsports.com/dunkin-customer-accidentally-orders-6000-donuts-instead-of-60-and-the-store-turned-the-mistake-into-a-wholesome-display/

Backup options:

■ ***Stanford University admits AI was used to 'race swap' student photo***

The Angle: *Stanford University admits AI was used to 'race swap' student photo*

Reddit r/nottheonion (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://san.com/cc/stanford-university-admits-ai-was-used-to-race-swap-student-photo/

FLEX (cap check: THE GREAT DEBATE 1/5 this month; TECH TALK 3/3 this month; Advice/Relationship Cluster 4/3 this month)

(no flex-slot candidates cleared the cap/score bar today)

ADDITIONAL CANDIDATES (no specific segment match, but scored well on source/quality - producer's call on where these fit)

■ ***EPA to begin screening U.S. drinking water for traces of abortion pills***

The Angle: *It sounds like a headline from The Onion, but it's landed in r/nottheonion for a reason — the idea of the EPA sniffing your drinking water for trace medication is exactly the kind of absurd-but-real story that makes for a great water-cooler debate to close the show.*

- **r/nottheonion** flagged this one — the go-to sub for real headlines too weird to believe
- The claim: the **EPA** would begin screening **U.S. drinking water** for traces of **abortion pills**
- No agency statement or study details available yet beyond the headline itself

The Reality Check

- Real regulation or internet rumor mill — would you even trust a headline like this without digging deeper?

Reddit r/nottheonion (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://www.themirror.com/news/us-news/epa-begin-screening-us-drinking-2034312

BREAKOUT WATCH (below the show's usual engagement bar - included on editorial judgment, not metrics; producer's call)

■ ***Nike co-founder donates $1B to university — his latest massive charitable move***

■ **Breakout potential** (editorial judgment, below the usual engagement bar): Phil Knight's name plus a $1B headline number gives it built-in shareability that pure dollar-amount philanthropy posts rarely have.
The Angle: *A single person writing a check for a billion dollars to a school is the kind of number that stops people in their tracks — and it's not even his first massive gift, which makes it a great feel-good closer.*

- The **co-founder of Nike** just donated **$1 billion** to a university
- Reports frame it as his **latest** in a pattern of **massive charitable gifts**

The Feel-Good Finisher

- If you had a billion dollars sitting around, what's the one thing you'd fund?

Reddit r/upliftingnews (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://www.independent.co.uk/us/money/nike-phil-knight-university-of-oregon-donation-philanthropy-b3055118.html

■ ***Three years after seeing a Philadelphia school close because it lacked air conditioning, Jalen Hurts has donated $600,000 to air condition Northeast High's auditorium. He says he wants to help get the number of Philadelphia schools without AC to zero.***

■ **Breakout potential** (editorial judgment, below the usual engagement bar): Star NFL QB with a specific personal-origin story (he saw the school close over AC) hits during football season when Hurts is already in the news cycle.
The Angle: *It's the ultimate athlete-gives-back story — a hometown QB turning a memory of a school shutting down into a $600K fix, with a bigger goal attached. Perfect note to end the show on.*

- **Jalen Hurts** donated **$600,000** to install air conditioning in the auditorium at **Northeast High** in Philadelphia
- The move traces back three years, to when he saw a **Philadelphia school close because it had no AC**
- His stated goal: get the number of **Philly schools without air conditioning down to zero**

The Feel-Good Takeaway

- Name an athlete in our city who could pull off a hometown assist like this.

Reddit r/upliftingnews (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://www.inquirer.com/education/jalen-hurts-air-conditioning-philadelphia-northeast-high-school-20260915.html

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■ *Wendy's releases new emo album with metalcore, pop punk vocalists*

■ **Breakout potential** (editorial judgment, below the usual engagement bar): A fast-food chain releasing an actual emo/metalcore album is the kind of absurd-but-real corporate stunt that fuels its own meme cycle on social media.
The Angle: *A fast food chain making a scene-core record sounds like satire, but it's exactly the kind of brand-gone-viral stunt that gets people checking if it's real mid-scroll.*

- The chain is **Wendy's** — yes, the burger place.
- The project is described as an **emo album**.
- It reportedly features **metalcore and pop punk vocalists**.

The Reality Check

- Guess which fast food chain just "dropped an emo album" — bet the phones can't call it.

Reddit r/nottheonion (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://www.usatoday.com/story/money/food/2026/09/23/wendys-emo-music-album/91904303007/

■ *Radio executive had 'innocent explanation' for €111k cannabis delivery to workplace*

■ **Breakout potential** (editorial judgment, below the usual engagement bar): "Innocent explanation for €111k cannabis delivery" is a pull-quote so absurd it invites screenshotting and spreads on headline alone.
The Angle: *A radio executive reportedly had a six-figure cannabis shipment sent straight to the office — and had an excuse ready to go. It's a pure 'you can't make this up' lifestyle story built for two hosts to riff on.*

- A radio executive is reported to have received a **cannabis delivery worth €111,000** — sent directly to the workplace.
- The exec reportedly offered what's being described as an **'innocent explanation'** for the shipment.
- Story is making the rounds on **r/nottheonion**, the internet's home for real headlines that sound fake.

The Excuse Test

- What's the most 'innocent explanation' you've ever had to give at work?

ON-AIR BIT BREAKDOWN

- **Step 1: Drop the Number First** - ~30 seconds -> Read the €111,000 figure and let it land before revealing it's cannabis, and that it went to an office.
- **Step 2: Hosts Pitch Their Own Excuse** - 2-3 minutes -> Each host has to improvise their own over-the-top 'innocent explanation' for something absurd showing up at their job.
- **Step 3: Open the Phone Lines** - caller segment -> Ask listeners to call or text in the wildest 'innocent explanation' they've actually used at work.

Reddit r/nottheonion (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://www.irishtimes.com/crime-law/courts/2026/09/23/radio-executive-had-innocent-explanation-for-111k-cannabis-delivery-to-workplace/

■ *Stanford R&DE Uses AI to Race Swap Students for Advertising*

■ **Breakout potential** (editorial judgment, below the usual engagement bar): AI-powered race-swapping of students for ads sits squarely on the AI-ethics/race hot button and is exactly the kind of story that generates outraged shares.
The Angle: *A university department reportedly used AI to digitally change students' race in promotional materials - which is exactly the kind of "wait, they did WHAT" headline that makes r/nottheonion a goldmine, and it's a fresh flashpoint in the ongoing AI-authenticity debate.*

- Stanford's **Residential & Dining Enterprises (R&DE)** is at the center of the story
- The allegation: AI was used to **race swap students** in advertising materials
- Story is circulating via **r/nottheonion**, meaning it's being read as too absurd to be real - but is

The 'Wait, Seriously?' Reaction

- Where's the line between 'diverse stock photo' and flat-out digitally editing a real student's race?

Reddit r/nottheonion (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://stanfordreview.org/stanford-r-de-uses-ai-to-race-swap-students-for-advertising/

■ *When the Shield Strikes the Citizen: Inside the Botched ICE Operation That Left an American Injured*

■ **Breakout potential** (editorial judgment, below the usual engagement bar): ICE enforcement stories involving an injured American citizen are landing in an already white-hot immigration news cycle and tend to spike fast.
The Angle: *A law enforcement operation that hits the wrong person is exactly the kind of story that fuels the ongoing national debate over ICE tactics and accountability — and this one's got a headline so blunt it reads like satire.*

- The story centers on an **ICE operation** that reportedly went sideways and left an **American citizen injured**.
- It's framed as "**When the Shield Strikes the Citizen**" — a jab at law enforcement hurting the very public it's supposed to protect.
- It's blowing up on **r/nottheonion**, the subreddit dedicated to real stories too absurd to believe.

The Accountability Angle

- When the people enforcing the law end up hurting an innocent citizen, who actually answers for it?

Reddit r/nottheonion (Tier 1) | Score: 78/90 (45 fit + 12 source + 21 quality) -> LEAD

URL: https://kylesinvestigation.com/2026/09/23/when-the-shield-strikes-the-citizen-inside-the-botched-ice-operation-that-left-an-american-injured/

FRANCHISE BANK

WHAT THE FRIDAY: 4 banked (+15 each when found)
- "Tiny mouse brawl breaks out on London subway platform" (nypost.com, banked 2026-09-08)
- "Dramatic video shows naked man being pulled from East River by NYC cops" (nypost.com, banked 2026-09-09)
- "Lady wtf, your kid is right there!" (X/Twitter @WomenBeingAwful, banked 2026-09-16)
- "Channing Tatum addresses claims he trolled ex Zoë Kravitz online using burner account: ‘Wtf come on’" (Entertainment Weekly (via Google News), banked 2026-09-22)

THROWBACK THURSDAY: 19 banked (+15 each when found)
- "Here’s Why Fifth Harmony Fans Think the Girl Group Is Making a Comeback Ahead of Anniversary" (X/Twitter @Billboard, banked 2026-09-06)
- "Rachael Leigh Cook surprises fans at ‘Josie and the Pussycats’ 25th anniversary screening" (pagesix.com, banked 2026-09-07)
- "Stevie Wonder Announces ‘Songs in the Key of Life’ 50th Anniversary Tour https://t.co/trmKJsgwqb" (X/Twitter @Variety, banked 2026-09-08)
- "Michael Goodwin: Mamdani’s toxic Ground Zero blame game just latches on to still-open 9/11 wounds to boost himself" (nypost.com, banked 2026-09-08)
- "John Oliver to Host Comic Relief Live’s 40th Anniversary Show" (www.hollywoodreporter.com, banked 2026-09-09)

- "Where I was on 9/11: 4 people in N.L. share their stories of stepping up to help" (www.cbc.ca, banked 2026-09-11)
- "Gander mayor reflects on 25th anniversary of 9/11" (CTV News (via Google News), banked 2026-09-11)
- "Globe editorial: Nostalgia is no strategy for U.S. relations" (The Globe and Mail (via Google News), banked 2026-09-11)
- "Universal Studios Japan Celebrates Halloween With First R-Rated Attraction" (gizmodo.com, banked 2026-09-13)
- "'Practical Magic 2' Dazzles Up a Bit Of an Audience" (gizmodo.com, banked 2026-09-14)
- "The London revival of "Sunday in the Park With George" has been canceled following the exits of stars Ariana Grande and Jonathan Bailey." (X/Twitter @Variety, banked 2026-09-14)
- "'Sunday in the Park With George' London Revival Canceled After Ariana Grande, Jonathan Bailey Exits https://t.co/cPQ2IIvYql" (X/Twitter @Variety, banked 2026-09-14)
- "'Sunday in the Park With George' revival scrapped after Ariana Grande, Jonathan Bailey exits" (Entertainment Weekly (via Google News), banked 2026-09-14)
- "Margot Robbie stuns in a retro bikini as she joins shirtless Bradley Cooper to shoot the Ocean's Eleven 1960s prequel on the French Riviera" (www.dailymail.co.uk, banked 2026-09-16)
- "Here's Why Fifth Harmony Fans Think the Girl Group Is Making a Comeback Ahead of Anniversary" (X/Twitter @Billboard, banked 2026-09-20)
- "NCT 127 Open 10th-Anniversary 'Neo City: The Redline' Tour With Sold-Out Seoul Run" (X/Twitter @Billboard, banked 2026-09-22)
- "1Retro adds cloud saves to RetroArch, OpenEmu, and other gaming platforms" (www.techspot.com, banked 2026-09-22)
- "NCT 127 Open 10th-Anniversary 'Neo City: The Redline' Tour With Sold-Out Seoul Run" (X/Twitter @Billboard, banked 2026-09-23)
- "'The Visit' at Pasadena Playhouse Review: The '50s Absurdist Comedy Is Too Smug in Its Peak-Bleak View of Venal Humanity, but Jefferson Mays and Melinda Page Hamilton Are Worth the Visit" (variety.com, banked 2026-09-23)

Newly banked this run:

- THROWBACK THURSDAY: "'The Visit' at Pasadena Playhouse Review: The '50s Absurdist Comedy Is Too Smug in Its Peak-Bleak View of Venal Humanity, but Jefferson Mays and Melinda Page Hamilton Are Worth the Visit"

SOURCES SKIPPED THIS RUN:

- @CBCNews (fetch failed)
- @Gizmodo (no posts cleared the 30+ likes bar - 5 below-bar candidate(s) considered for breakout potential)
- 1 story(ies) removed after slotting (content-safety and/or not-significant-enough for THE LIST/TRENDING TODAY; automatically backfilled where possible; see run log)

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